

HOW DO WE KNOW THAT DINOSAURS EVEN EXISTED?

A long time ago, Earth was a monsters' world. With gigantic jaws and scaly skins, this group of creatures called dinosaurs dominated the planet for 160 million years. It may sound far-fetched, but proof of their existence is still with us today. Scientists have found the fossilized bones of dinosaurs and sometimes whole skeletons. These remains give an intriguing insight to ancient life and provide clear evidence that early examples of life were very different to those found today.

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DATING FOSSILS

Once fossils are found, paleontologists (scientists who study fossils) determine their approximate age using a method called radiometric dating. Fossils form in layers of rock that can be dated, with each layer older than the one above. Radiometric dating is reliable because it agrees with other dating methods, such as geology and astronomical observations of Earth's rotation. By dating fossils, an accurate timeline of evolution is compiled.

FOSSIL FINDS

In 1818, British geologist William Buckland discovered a giant fossilized jaw in Oxfordshire, England. This exciting find was one of the first-known discoveries of dinosaur remains. By the end of the 1800s, many more fossils were found. They formed when dinosaurs died and were quickly covered by mud. Soft body parts rotted, leaving only bones and other hard parts behind. In time, these hard parts broke down into minerals, leaving rocky copies of the originals. Evidence for the existence of dinosaurs has now been discovered on every continent.

DINOSAUR LIVING

Fossils help paleontologists reconstruct what dinosaurs looked like, how they moved, and what they ate. Sharp teeth and claws suggest that a dinosaur ate meat. This type of dinosaur was bipedal (two-footed), which enabled it to quickly chase prey. Plant-eating dinosaurs were usually quadrupeds (four-footed), with teeth suited to grinding vegetation. Fossilized footprints indicate dinosaur weight and confirm that they traveled in groups, with the young in the middle to protect them.